

CRICKET

CRICKET VISION

As the Indian Premier League moves towards micro-segmentation of its viewers, the cricket-viewing experience is shifting towards greater personalisation

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

18 | ► **THE SOCIAL MILIEU** in India has changed considerably from the 1990s to now and nowhere is this shift better chronicled than in the act of watching cricket. In the 90s, Doordarshan (DD) was still the norm, and cable television had only just begun to gain popularity. As matches moved from government-owned DD to private networks, homes with cable TV often opened their doors—quite literally—to neighbours who didn't have access. Watching cricket was a community activity, one that often blurred class lines.

Since then, viewership has shifted towards increased personalisation, reflecting the broader trend of individualisation in social interactions and experiences.

From television screens earlier, matches are now viewed on a six-inch mobile screen. The product enabling the experience, MaxView, was first piloted during the Asia Cup 2023. The second version was introduced during last year's T20 World Cup, but it was the marquee Indian Premier League (IPL) 2025 telecast by JioStar that truly has set a new benchmark. For the broadcaster, who owns the television and digital rights to the IPL, as well as the rights for the

tournaments conducted by the International Cricket Council (ICC) and the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI), this is a big breakthrough.

"It is shot very differently and custom-made for the small screen. Most of our tasks on the mobile are done vertically and to change that while watching a match is a pain point," says Sanjog Gupta, CEO (Sports),

vice launched last year, but is now being actively promoted. "The strategy is to build a customised, yet converged, experience. Viewers need to be served anytime and anywhere with multiple screens," says Gupta.

Effectively, it all comes down to personalisation for a product that has mass viewing.

The build-up to the IPL, which commences in mid-March and lasts till May-end, begins the previous November. Naturally, the innovation pipeline gets updated each season to make it more palatable to the viewers. And innovation must cater to all segments of viewers. Ravi Bhaya, Chief Client Officer, Publicis Media India, outlines how audience segmentation in the IPL has evolved from demographics to dynamic cohorts. "They are now defined by behaviour, preferences, and context. Now, it is about how people watch, what devices they use, what language they prefer, and who they cheer for. Mobile-first fans in Tier 2 towns or Tamil-speaking viewers who stream with regional commentary are some examples," he says. The objective is clear to Gupta, that since the game must stay relevant for at least 30 years, growth cannot happen only through deepened engagement

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JioStar. It also allows the viewer to check emails or WhatsApp messages or even sneakily watch a bit of the game during a meeting, without attracting attention. The approach prioritises being "consumer-first" rather than "product-first." One example is the ability to watch live action on a big screen while simultaneously catching up on missed moments on a mobile device. This is enabled through a QR code, a ser-